

DIGITAL SOLUTION BUILDERS

Freetown, Sierra Leone

THE CV THAT GETS YOU SHORTLISTED

A free guide from
The Global African Professional

Daniel Solomon Bangura

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All example documents, templates, and excerpts shown in this guide are the author's own and have been redacted.

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INTRODUCTION

The CV That Gets You Shortlisted

There are six versions of my CV in the folder my career playbook was built from, written between 2021 and 2026, and they tell the same career in two very different ways. The 2021 version belongs to a civil-service pharmacist doing surveillance work in Sierra Leone. The 2026 versions belong to a founder directing AI products. Same history, same person.

My name is Daniel Solomon Bangura. I have spent my working life in Sierra Leone's health system, from pharmacy and frontline surveillance through field epidemiology to building digital health products, and this guide is the condensed CV chapter of my playbook, The Global African Professional. Everything quoted in it is lifted from my real files, redacted only where privacy requires it, including the material that does not flatter me.

One idea sits underneath everything else here. Your CV is a claims document. Every line is a claim about what you did and what it caused, and every reader, the applicant tracking system (ATS), the recruiter moving fast through a stack, the referee taking a verification call, is testing those claims. Engineering a CV means building each claim deliberately, then testing it before anyone else does.

The same career, told twice

Start with the summary, because it is the first claim a reader meets and the one most professionals waste. Here is mine from 2021, complete.

FROM MY FILES

My 2021 CV summary, verbatim and complete.

“A pharmacist with strong experience in surveillance activities related to AFP, monitoring of adverse events following immunization (Polio and Ebola vaccines), rapid mortality and polio immunization campaigns. Team oriented, result driven and trustworthy. I possess knowledge and skills related to the equitable delivery of Global Health interventions.”

That is a category label plus a character reference I wrote for myself. “Team oriented, result driven and trustworthy” asks the reader to accept three adjectives nobody can verify, and the only concrete content is a list of activity areas I had worked in, from Acute Flaccid Paralysis (AFP) surveillance to mortality surveillance. Nothing in it says what happened because I was there.

Now the version from June 2026, also complete.

FROM MY FILES

My June 2026 positioning summary, verbatim and complete.

FROM MY FILES

“Pharmacist and Global Health Delivery specialist (MSc) with 8+ years leading field surveillance and digital health operations across Sierra Leone, now Founder and CEO of [my company]. An AI-native builder: ships production-grade AI products (EMR, LMIS, mortality-surveillance platform) by directing AI coding agents rather than writing code, owning system architecture, product decisions, and an adapted eight-layer AI governance framework operated as a live release gate. Combines deep public health credibility (Ebola vaccine trial, polio/AFP surveillance, Rapid Mortality Surveillance) with Responsible and Applied AI leadership for low-connectivity, high-stakes settings.”

Notice what is gone: every self-assessed character trait. What came in instead is a credential stack with the years attached and an identity claim backed by named products, and then the closing sentence does the real selling, stating the rare combination on offer and the exact settings I am built for. The 2021 version describes what I had been near. The 2026 version argues what only I can do.

The change did not happen in one jump. A 2024 version sits between the two, with better nouns and a longer list of domains, and it still self-certified (“I am team-oriented and result-driven”) while offering no evidence. That half-evolved stage is where most CVs I review get stuck: better nouns, same missing proof.

The June 2026 CV also does something I recommend to anyone making a bold identity claim: it states plainly what I am not.

FROM MY FILES

The exclusion list in my June 2026 CV, verbatim.

“Honest ‘not me’ (require hands-on coding): AI Application Developer · Data Engineer · Data Scientist · ML Engineer · Model Validator · AI Cybersecurity Analyst. I direct these capabilities; I do not personally code them.”

Stating what you are not is a credibility move almost nobody makes. It answers the obvious objection before an interviewer can raise it, and it makes every claim around it easier to believe.

Duties versus outcomes

A duty bullet answers “what did you do all day.” An outcome bullet answers “what existed because you were there.” The single most valuable edit you can make to your CV is converting the first kind into the second, and the honest way to show it is with a matched pair from my own files, the same facts told both ways.

FROM MY FILES

Afp surveillance scale-up, July 2024 versus May 2026.

FROM MY FILES

BEFORE (2024): “Supervised the 70 FETP officers to carry out active Acute Flaccid Paralysis (AFP) surveillance in over 500 health facilities according to WHO prioritization. Active surveillance visits increased 90-fold between 2020 and 2021.”

AFTER (2026): “Scaled Acute Flaccid Paralysis (AFP) surveillance across Sierra Leone by supervising 70 FETP graduates in active surveillance at 500+ health facilities and installing project-specific monitoring checklists on Kobo Collect and WHO eSurve on ODK, resulting in a 90-fold increase in active surveillance visits between 2020 and 2021.”

This is the cleanest demonstration of the method I can give you, because the impressive number already existed in the earlier version. In 2024 the 90-fold figure is present but bolted on as a second sentence, trailing the duty with no causal link. In 2026 the verb becomes “Scaled,” supervising 70 Field Epidemiology Training Program (FETP) graduates becomes the method, and the 90-fold increase is welded into the sentence as the direct result. Same facts in both versions, but only one makes a causal claim a hiring manager can repeat in a shortlisting meeting, which is the entire job of a CV bullet.

Deletion is the other half of this discipline. Several of my 2021 bullets have no descendant in any later version, and their disappearance is itself a lesson.

FROM MY FILES

Three 2021 bullets that no later version kept.

“Submits bi-weekly project reports to AFENET.” “Responds to technical queries on the tools installed on android devices.” “Installs data abstraction tools on android devices for both on- and offline use.”

Reporting to your own employer and answering questions about your own tools are table stakes. They prove you showed up, not that you mattered, and every line they occupy is a line a real accomplishment cannot use.

The XYZ formula

Every experience bullet in my May 2026 CV follows one three-slot pattern:

[Outcome verb + headline result X] by [method and scope Y], resulting in [downstream impact Z].

Two house rules hold across the document. First, the X slot always opens with a strong causal verb: Established, Scaled, Prevented, Ensured, Built. Second, the Z slot tries to name a consequence that outlived the task: an adopted plan, an uninterrupted supply line, a named report reaching named institutions.

Here is one of them, decomposed.

FROM MY FILES

Project Last Mile role, May 2026, verbatim.

“Prevented a critical reproductive health commodity distribution failure during US funding cuts by conducting a comprehensive status review across five supported districts and developing an evidence-based gap-closure plan, resulting in uninterrupted last-mile distribution of family planning and reproductive health commodities.”

X is “Prevented a critical reproductive health commodity distribution failure during US funding cuts,” which sets the stake without a single adjective of self-praise. Y is the status review across five districts and the gap-closure plan, the method stated at a scope someone could audit. Z is uninterrupted distribution of the commodities themselves, the consequence the employer cared about more than any review.

One warning from my own overuse: the phrase “resulting in” appears in roughly three quarters of my May 2026 bullets, back to back, and at that density recruiters start to see the template instead of the person. Vary the connective, or restructure the sentence entirely. The skeleton should stay internal.

Keep an evidence file

Look at where the strong number in that AFP bullet came from. The 90-fold increase was already recorded in my 2024 CV, written close to the work it describes. The same holds across my files: the 27 data collectors I trained and the 4,000 trial participants my team monitored, two of the strongest numbers in my 2026 bullets, were already sitting in the 2021 CV. Numbers recorded close to the work survived every rewrite and are still safe in an interview today, while the claims I reconstructed years later to satisfy a formula are exactly the ones I have to walk back in the next section.

So build an evidence file: one running document where you record the result when it happens and note where it is written down. Facilities visited, people trained, budget managed, the report the figure appears in, the institution that received it. Five minutes at the end of each month is enough.

You can only quantify later what you recorded at the time. Memory rounds up, flattens dates, and merges projects, and a CV built from memory inherits all three habits.

DO THIS NOW

Open a blank document and title it Evidence File. Write five entries from the past year, each with a number and a note on where that number is documented. Then pick the one bullet on your CV you are most proud of and rebuild it in the XYZ shape: outcome verb and headline result, method and scope in a “by” clause, then the downstream impact.

The honest part: verification

Real documents have real defects, and mine are no exception. My May 2026 CV closes three bullets with “zero” claims, including “resulting in zero protocol deviations” on a clinical trial from a decade earlier. I wrote those closes years after the fact, to satisfy the formula. An interviewer who asks “how was protocol deviation tracked, and who audited the zero?” collapses the bullet, and the collapse takes the true parts down with it. The rule I now hold myself to: if the Z is not in a report you could produce, do not write it.

Dates drift too. Across my versions in circulation, one role ends “Mar 2023” in two documents and “April 2023” in a third, and both 2026 summaries still say “8+ years” when the true figure had passed ten, because the line was copy-pasted forward without being re-read. Any one of these is trivial. Together, documents circulating in the same month contradict each other, and catching exactly that is what background-check processes are built for.

So make verification a standing part of CV work, not a one-time proofread. Before any version leaves your machine, check every proper noun against its source, check every date against your records and against every other version still out there, and check every number against the document it came from. Your CV is a claims document, and the most impressive document in the stack loses to the modest one where everything checks out.

Where this guide comes from

This guide is the condensed CV chapter of The Global African Professional, my career playbook for African and diaspora professionals building global careers on home-country experience. The full chapter goes further than a free guide can: the complete set of before-and-after bullet pairs, the structural changes across all six versions of my CV, the one-master-many-variants system that stops tailoring accidents, the ATS mechanics, and the full defect list I audit my own files against. The playbook costs USD 29, with the Leone equivalent shown at checkout, and it is published by Digital Solution Builders at dsbdigital.biz.

Inside the playbook:

- Eight chapters: the career capital audit, CV engineering, LinkedIn as distribution, applications and cover letters, interviews and negotiation, reading your contract, credentials strategy, and the three-lane arc of employed, consultant, and founder.
- Five fill-in templates: the XYZ CV Template, the Career Capital Tracker, a Cover Letter Template, a LinkedIn Worksheet, and a Contract Review Checklist.
- Real documents throughout: my actual CVs, contracts, and LinkedIn material, with the weak lines shown as openly as the strong ones.

If this guide was useful, the playbook is the same method applied to the whole journey, from the first audit of what you already carry to the contract you sign at the end of it. Start tonight with the three bullets you are most proud of. The rest builds from there.